▼ SHOBHA BACHHAV, *64*

| CONGRESS | *Dhule, Maharashtra*

In 1992, the Congress—while looking for a woman candidate for the Nashik civic polls from Peth Road-Panchavati—chose Bachhav. She was the first woman with a medical practice in the area, having earned her now-defunct LCEH degree in 1983. Bachhav won, backed mainly by slum-dwellers who were her patients. She later went on to become the first woman mayor of Nashik, serving until 2002. In 2004, Bachhav, a Maratha, inflicted defeat on another Maratha and doctor, the senior BJP leader Daulatrao Aher, in the assembly poll and became a minister. After a decade of political obscurity, she returned as an LS candidate from Dhule. Also a director of the Nashik District Central Cooperative Bank for 25 years, Bachhav runs a 30-bed nursing home with her husband and occasionally finds time to see her patients.



▶ PRASHANT PADOLE, *45*

| CONGRESS | *Bhandara-Gondiya, Maharashtra*



When the Congress nominated the little-known Padole, he was thought to be a proxy for state party chief Nana Patole, who had won the seat in 2014 but chose to sit it out this time. The Ukraine-educated doctor proved his worth when he defeated BJP's Sunil Baburao Mendhe. Son of influential cooperatives leader Yadavrao Padole, Prashant was elected director of the local cooperative milk federation in 2005. In 2014, he had fought from the Sakoli assembly seat on a Sena ticket, but lost.



◀ HEMANG JOSHI, *33*

| BJP | *Vadodara, Gujarat*

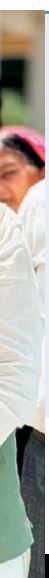
Joshi wears many hats. After a bachelor's degree in physiotherapy, he did his master's in human resource management; he is also a poet and writer. The city convenor of the BJP's Doctor Cell and Yuva Morcha got a big boost in his career when he was chosen for Vadodara, a prize seat where PM Modi contested in 2014. He bettered Modi's winning margin of 570,000 votes with a lead of 582,000 votes.



◀ BYREDDY SHABARI, *40*

| TDP | *Nandyal, Andhra Pradesh*

A radiologist who runs a clinic with her gastroenterologist husband in Kurnool, Shabari is the only woman MP of the TDP. She is the daughter of Byreddy Rajasekhar, a former TDP minister, who founded the Rayalaseema Parirakshana Samithi, which opposed Andhra Pradesh's bifurcation and demanded a separate Rayalaseema region if Telangana was granted statehood. Her grandfather, Byreddy Seshsayana Reddy, was a three-term MLA.



votes. A resident of Depot Market in Dharamshala, Bharadwaj is affectionately known as "depot wale doctor sahib". He got noticed for his work with families displaced during the construction of Pong Dam—a group he himself belongs to, as his native village Mangwal in Dehra tehsil was submerged by the dam's waters.



◀ KALYANRAO KALE, *61*

| CONGRESS | *Jalna, Maharashtra*

The homoeopath and his electoral rival Raosaheb Danve, a prominent BJP leader and former Union minister, shared not just political battles but also family ties. In 2009, Kale posed a formidable challenge to him. This time around, he approached the contest with reluctance. But fortune favoured Kale, and the winning margin was over 100,000 votes. His journey in the assembly has seen him represent two different seats: Aurangabad East and Phulambri.

–Ajay Sukumaran, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Rahul Noronha, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon, Prashant Srivastava, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Jumana Shah